

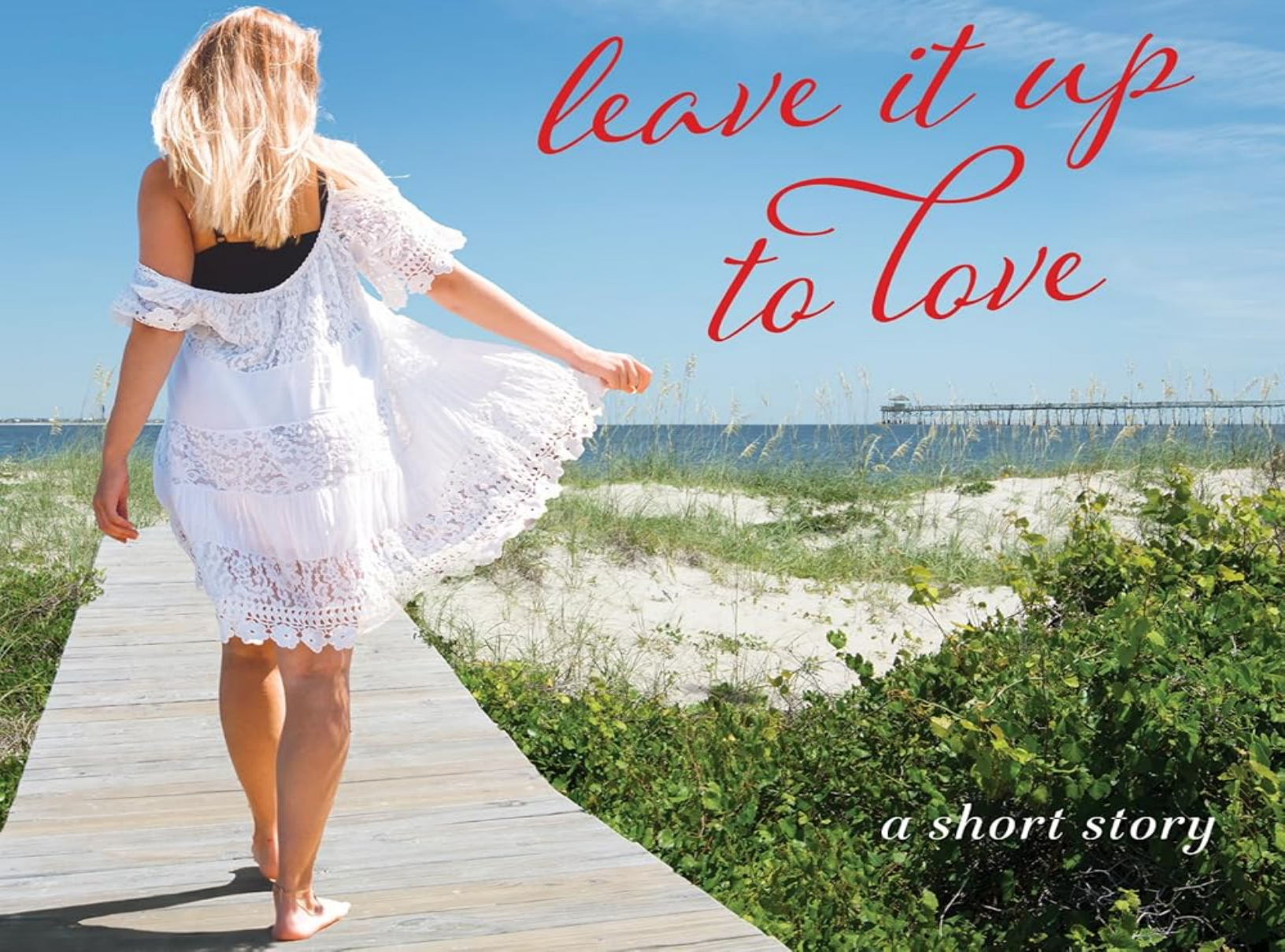
AMAZON ORIGINAL STORIES

KRISTY WOODSON HARVEY

NEW YORK TIMES BESTSELLING AUTHOR

*leave it up
to love*

a short story



AMAZON ORIGINAL STORIES

KRISTY
WOODSON
HARVEY

*leave it up
to love*

a short story

OceanofPDF.com

This is a work of fiction. Names, characters, organizations, places, events, and incidents are either products of the author's imagination or are used fictitiously. Otherwise, any resemblance to actual persons, living or dead, is purely coincidental.

Text copyright © 2026 by Kristy Woodson Harvey Author, LLC
All rights reserved.

No part of this book may be reproduced, or stored in a retrieval system, or transmitted in any form or by any means, electronic, mechanical, photocopying, recording, or otherwise, without express written permission of the publisher.

Published by Amazon Original Stories, Seattle
www.apub.com

Amazon, the Amazon logo, and Amazon Original Stories are trademarks of Amazon.com, Inc., or its affiliates.

EU product safety contact:
Amazon Media EU S. à r.l.
38, avenue John F. Kennedy, L-1855 Luxembourg
amazonpublishing-gpsr@amazon.com

ISBN-13: 9781662539299 (digital)

Cover design by Kathleen Lynch/Black Kat Design
Cover image: © Ziga Plahutar, © Chris Hackett/Tetra Images / Getty



[OceanofPDF.com](https://oceanofpdf.com)

*To all the authors who have come alongside me on this
writing journey with their friendship, advice, and guidance,
especially*

*Mary Kay Andrews, Kristin Harmel, and Patti Callahan
Henry.*

You inspire me every day.

OceanofPDF.com

CONTENTS

[CHAPTER 1: Book Club–Pick Glow LILA](#)

[CHAPTER 2: Heartless Cappuccino ELIZABETH](#)

[CHAPTER 3: Bottom of the Mid-List LILA](#)

[CHAPTER 4: Writer’s Block ELIZABETH](#)

[CHAPTER 5: Romantic Hero LILA](#)

[CHAPTER 6: A Damn Good Chapter ELIZABETH](#)

[CHAPTER 7: No-Wake Zone LILA](#)

[CHAPTER 8: Falling in Love Again ELIZABETH](#)

[CHAPTER 9: Wondrous View LILA](#)

[CHAPTER 10: Leave It Up to Love ELIZABETH](#)

[ACKNOWLEDGMENTS](#)

[ABOUT THE AUTHOR](#)

[*OceanofPDF.com*](#)

CHAPTER 1

Book Club–Pick Glow

LILA

My favorite part about being an author was days like today, when I was walking down a Sea Oat Shores, North Carolina, street to meet with my editor. At my *publishing house*. I was buzzing with anticipation, because what else could an impromptu meeting mean except for good news?

As I reached the stunning cast-iron building with three stories of floor-to-ceiling windows that held Apprentice Publishing, I looked up at the gleaming golden accents and marveled that this building and this small press had been here since 1878. I took a moment, as my wedges clapped on the original wide plank floor of the lobby, to appreciate that, when I was in college, I used to walk by this building every day and dream about what went on inside. I, a girl from a tiny, sleepy farming town, who had wanted a life by the sea, a life in books, was here; I had made it.

“Hello, Stella!” I practically sang to the small woman with a set curled hairdo like my grandmother’s, who was sitting behind the antique desk in the lobby. Stella answered the phones and greeted people in this building, where Apprentice—along with two other businesses and dozens of coworking office spaces—was housed. I handed her a french vanilla latte from Salty Sip, the coffee shop where I worked to make ends meet, with my signature heart drawn on the cup. She winked at me and said, “Well, thank you, darlin’. You made my day!” as I headed toward the elevator.

Maybe I’d be able to quit Salty Sip after whatever this news was. I envisioned finding out my debut novel had won a huge award or prize, or leaving here with that I’m-a-book-club-pick glow.

My toes tingled with excitement as Jamie, my editor, met me at the elevator door. I hugged her, hoping that whatever was happening was going

to be huge for her too. We had both just turned thirty, and the milestone had given us a common bond outside of our work.

Jamie led me to her small but bright office. It had a stunning view of the sound, which more than made up for its size. I had been to Apprentice in person only once before, for the marketing-and-publicity meeting for my first novel. Its sales hadn't set the world on fire, but they had been respectable. I had submitted two ideas for the second novel in that contract, and I was imagining that Jamie loved them both so much, she wanted to offer me another contract in person before I'd even fulfilled this one!

Apprentice wasn't a huge publishing house, but it was the house of my dreams. They published Elizabeth Lancaster, my idol. With ninety-four bestsellers, she was the undeniable queen of Regency romance. She had appeared on every major morning show and was nothing short of a household name.

Jamie gestured for me to sit down in the white pleather barrel chair across from her desk. "Thanks for coming in today," she said.

"Of course! Any time. Any time at all."

Jamie folded her hands on the desk and said, "Look, Lila, I don't quite know how to say this. I've read your new ideas and passed them along to the higher-ups, and we're just afraid that they're a little . . ." She squirmed in her seat.

I mean, no, this wasn't starting particularly *well*, but one great adjective could turn this whole thing around.

Jamie started again. "Lila, are you familiar with Elizabeth Lancaster?"

"Um, isn't *everyone*?"

Jamie laughed uncomfortably.

"I positively worship Elizabeth," I said. "She is the reason I wanted to become a writer. When I was a teenager, I would buy her used paperbacks for fifty cents and sneak them into the house. Of course, now I would never buy a used book, but . . ." I was rambling. I served Elizabeth her coffee most mornings at Salty Sip. I had never gotten up the nerve to introduce myself. I didn't want to fangirl and risk Elizabeth not coming back. So I quietly served her a whole-milk cappuccino every morning and drew a heart in the foam. Because I *loved* her.

At a light rap on the door, I turned and practically jumped out of my chair. It was the goddess of Apprentice: Victoria Abbott, the glossy,

gorgeous, stiletto-wearing publisher. She'd had a big dream to start a seaside publishing house, and when she had poached Elizabeth Lancaster from the large NYC press where she had published her first sixty-one books, no one had been able to believe it. But that one brilliant move had put Apprentice on the map, and after seeing how Victoria had skyrocketed Elizabeth's already stellar career, other authors flocked to Apprentice too.

"Hi, Lila," she said smoothly.

"Hi, Victoria!" I was aware of how high pitched and young I sounded in contrast. And Southern. Very, very *Southern*.

As Victoria sat down, Jamie said, "We're just getting started."

Victoria nodded. "Great, then let's cut right to the chase. Lila," she said, turning her full attention to me, "we're concerned that your pitches are a little stale, a little *we've seen that before*." She paused. "More specifically, they are a little too close to Elizabeth Lancaster's."

I couldn't say that didn't sting. Then my breath caught in my throat. Did they think I had *stolen* Elizabeth's ideas? This was one of those moments when I regretted not having an agent. Apprentice was a boutique press that accepted unagented submissions, so it hadn't seemed necessary. But now, I had no idea how to handle this. "Well, um," I stuttered. "They are Regency romance, so they probably do feel a little familiar, but—"

"You're great at writing Regency," she said, cutting me off. "We signed you thinking you would be a good fit as our next-gen Regency writer. But now, with fans clamoring for Elizabeth's next book, we're worried releasing anything else in the same genre would be unsatisfying for them. And since you are obviously familiar with her work, we wondered if you would consider ghostwriting for her instead."

My jaw dropped, and my head swiveled from Jamie to Victoria and back to Jamie. Victoria was known to be the no-nonsense firm hand of the publishing house, but wow. Talk about dropping a bomb. Although this was obviously considerably better than their thinking I had stolen Elizabeth's ideas, so that was something.

Victoria continued: "Just think what a learning opportunity this would be. Real, hands-on writing with one of the greats."

I blew out my breath. I mean, sure, yes, I was enamored with Elizabeth. But I was trying to make my own name, my own way. I couldn't

put my own career on hold to support someone else's. "Does she always do this? Have a ghostwriter?"

"Most certainly not," Victoria said. "But Elizabeth has been going through a bit of a—shall we say—dry spell. And we just can't keep putting off her next publication. We thought a ghostwriter could be a good solution for everyone."

I shook my head. "And she asked for me?"

Victoria let out a low laugh. "Oh, no. We have no idea if she will even agree. But, well, at this point, she might not have a choice."

A man I didn't know with bushy eyebrows hurried in and dropped a stack of papers in front of Victoria. "That NDA you requested, Mrs. Abbott."

"Thank you, Wade," she called to the man's back. She smiled at me. "Wade's not really one for small talk."

I knew I needed a lawyer, but I didn't have the money for that, so I took the papers and said, "I'm going to need to read these."

"Of course," Victoria said smoothly. "But can I take that as a yes? We're really on a time crunch here."

My mind raced with all the Bookstagrammers I'd reached out to, the essay ideas I'd pitched, the social media I was desperately trying to grow. For my own author brand. For books I wouldn't be writing anymore. Worst of all, if I didn't have another novel, my whole hometown would know that I was a failure. I would have to go back, tail between my legs, the dreamer who couldn't hack it. "If I do this, would you take a look at another idea from me? Maybe in a different genre, if you're worried Elizabeth and I would overlap too much? What about something contemporary? Contemporary romance is so in right now!"

Jamie looked at Victoria and then nodded. "I think Elizabeth might be our Regency queen. But we could use a contemporary princess for sure."

"Or a romantasy regent?" Victoria quipped.

I wanted to take part in the fun, but I was dangerously close to crying. I had gotten a friend to cover my shift at Salty Sip for only an hour and a half. I had imagined how I'd burst back in with amazing news. But now that was all over. Everything was over.

I had a vision of leaving Salty Sip and going to the liquor store. Not for alcohol. For empty boxes. Because if I didn't do this, there would be no

choice but to pack up my belongings and head back home. I was the bright, golden small-town girl who was going to make it big. And now my star had burned out before it had ever even had a chance to rise.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 2

Heartless Cappuccino

ELIZABETH

A writer's world is a world built on routine. Sure, it is shaped by passion, by vision, by those extraordinary bursts of light, moments of "knowing." But its foundation is rather dull. And I had mine: morning water, beach walk, pair of hard-boiled eggs, cup of coffee. A moment alone with my journal on the front porch, clearing my mind. Then writing. Two thousand words, come hell or high water.

Except . . . I hadn't written one stark word in more than three years.

Yet today I woke up feeling levelheaded, hopeful, *ready*. Yes, it had been a while since I had written. But today was the day that would change all that. I threw on my exercise clothes, had my glass of water, and laced my shoes. The morning air felt warm and good, the sand smooth and nearly untouched by humans this early. The seagulls sang, and waves lapped the shore, and by the time I had had my eggs and my coffee, I knew I was ready.

I sat in my favorite chair on the porch, admiring the water, my legs curled around me. I opened a brand-new notebook, took out a pen, and willed myself to write. Something. *Anything*. This didn't have to be for a book. It could be the smell of coffee. The birdsong. My thoughts about my future. But it wouldn't come.

Determined to get through this, I went inside and traded my new notebook for an old, well-worn one. It was full, but I managed to find a half-empty page. I reread what I had written three years ago to jog my memory and, once again, attempted to put pen to paper.

My hand simply would not move.

I took a sip of coffee and looked out over the water. It was so calm, so placid. I thought about Anthony, my late husband, about our beautiful life together. I had been his forthright, motivated, diligent wife. I was glad he

couldn't see me now. Even still, I couldn't muster but so much anger at myself. I was healing; it was a process. I had tried, and I would try again tomorrow. And the next day. It would come. I knew it would.

I finished my coffee and went inside my big empty house to put the mug in the dishwasher. Anthony and I had fantasized about a house at the end of the island, between the sound for him and the ocean for me. It was a rare plot of land, an extraordinary dream. And the irony that I found myself calmest, most held, on his sound side now wasn't lost on me.

I loved this old house, the way that it rambled. First, it had been a tiny fishing shack. Through the years, one owner had added a new kitchen, another a primary bedroom and bath. Anthony and I had added a garage and a sunroom, and reconfigured the floor plan quite a bit to create our dream home. I loved the original moldings, the leaded-glass windows, the mail slot on the old front door with its giant brass lock. It, like me, still held all its scars, remnants of the iterations it had lived through. This house, like me, had always been a work in progress.

I needed to clear my mind. I took to the beach again and made my way to Salty Sip for a perfect cappuccino, always my second and final cup of the day, once my reward for finishing my words, now one of the treats I gave myself for simply managing to breathe throughout the morning.

I noticed right away that my usual coffee girl wasn't there when I ordered. She made the best coffee in the city, and, well, I'd never say it out loud, but I enjoyed the heart she drew in the foam.

I was sitting on the porch at my favorite weathered teak table, looking out at the seagulls diving into the ocean, practically bathing in cicada song, when my darling son burst through the door in a polished suit and tie. He looked like he wanted to murder me. Well, perhaps *murder me* was hyperbolic. But what can I say? I'm a writer.

"Are you kidding me?" he asked, sliding into the seat across from me.

"Well, good morning to you, too, darling. Yes, my drink is fine, but not quite as good as usual. Thank you for asking."

As if I'd said nothing, he hiss-whispered, "Mother, Victoria just called and said you missed your deadline *again*. It has been three *years*."

My heart pounded at the mention. I obviously knew exactly how long it had been since I had poured my heart out on the page. At first, I thought it was writer's block. Now I suspected it was fear that tapping into that

deepest part of myself might make me face all the emotions I had been avoiding. Or, perhaps, it was fear that I had lost my touch. The sales for my last two books had been down. By not writing, was I protecting myself from the very real possibility that this career I loved so much was over for me? That I, at sixty-two, was no longer relevant to a readership that preferred its romance novels with fairies and dragons?

But I would never say that to my son. With him, I tried, always, to be that stoic pillar of a mother that I felt a man needed to be able to count on—in life and especially in our business dealings, since he was my agent. The best one I'd ever had, in fact.

He sat down and sighed. "She wants you to use a ghostwriter."

A laugh burst out of me. "Well, I hope you told her no."

"I can't *tell her no*. We have no leg to stand on."

"Grady, you can't be serious!"

"Mother, you are *seriously* in breach of contract." He leaned forward. "Look, I'm worried about you. I know the last three years without Dad have been hard, but you are a writer. You take nothing and create an entire world for people to lose themselves in. Your readers need you. And, Mom, I think you need them. Getting back to the page, going back out on tour . . . It's time."

A familiar pain gripped my heart. My cappuccino might be heartless, but I was not. "I will if you will."

Grady looked puzzled. "What?"

I softened a little. My Grady and my Anthony could always do that: soften me. "Don't think I haven't noticed that you haven't been on so much as a date since Dad died." I paused. "And you are my perfect, devilishly handsome boy, so I *know* it isn't because women aren't interested."

We both laughed, but it was a little true. I did think he was perfect. So what? I birthed him. It was my prerogative.

I took his hand across the table. "Seriously. I know we don't talk about it much, but are you afraid to get close to anyone after losing him?"

A glimmer of recognition passed across Grady's face. "If I say yes, will you accept the ghostwriting offer?"

I smiled. We had always been close, but Anthony's death had brought us closer. Us against the world. Grady knew I was right; I knew that he was. I thought back to this morning and all the other mornings the past three

years that I had undertaken a similar ritual only to discover that I simply could not put the words on the page. This could be my solution. Or at least a stopgap.

“I will *meet* with this writer. That is all.”

Grady stood and picked up his phone.

“Where are you going?” I called.

“Victoria is going to be so excited,” he said, turning back to me.

“I haven’t said yes,” I reminded him. “At the very most, tell her *we’ll see*.”

But he wasn’t just my agent; Grady was my son. And he knew that, when it came to him, “we’ll see” almost always translated to yes.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 3

Bottom of the Mid-List

LILA

They say never meet your heroes. Which was only one of the reasons I was so nervous to be standing outside the front door of a sprawling waterfront home in Sea Oat Shores' most exclusive neighborhood, at the edge of downtown, where the ocean and the sound meet, with a to-go cappuccino in my hand. I had tossed and turned all night about whether I should do this. No, it wasn't what I *wanted*. It wasn't my book or my career. But I knew one thing for sure: I wanted to be a writer. I did not want to go home and milk cows and gather chicken eggs—as much as I truly loved each animal on the farm I grew up on. “Sometimes you have to fight for what you want,” I reminded myself, out loud. “Sometimes dreams take compromise.”

The door flew open, and a man with twinkling brown eyes, a ruggedly chiseled jaw, and effortless tousled hair, grinned at me mischievously. “That’s right,” he said. “It’s a long and winding road to our dreams.”

I could feel my cheeks redden. “Oh, uh . . .” I stammered.

He laughed easily. “I’m sorry. I’m Grady. Nice to meet you.” He stuck out his hand. “And I get that you might be talking yourself into this. And for good reason.” He looked around behind me. “Where’s your agent?”

“Oh, well,” I started sheepishly, “I don’t exactly have one.” If I did, would I even be in this mess?

“What?” Grady asked, alarmed. He put his hands in his pockets. “Oh, Lila . . . You always need an agent.”

“Yes. I’m realizing that. Thank you for that sage and well-timed advice.”

He gestured for me to walk in, following me. The floors looked to be original heart pine plank, but otherwise, the house was a sea of white upholstery.

This place was huge and gleaming and perfect, with light streaming through floor-to-ceiling windows showcasing the most glorious view of the ocean. I, meanwhile, was spending every cent I could scrape together from my *two* jobs to afford my tiny studio with a couple of paltry windows and some secondhand furniture—and generally feeling pretty happy about it because I didn’t have a roommate! I was reminded, being here, of what I hoped to achieve one day.

Elizabeth swanned into the room in a colorful caftan, looking like she was about to board a yacht, her chestnut bob perfectly styled. When she saw me, she stopped in her tracks. “It’s you!” She grinned widely. “I thought it was going to be some bottom-of-the-mid-list miscreant that they . . .” She waved her hand. “Oh, never mind. My darling barista is here to save the day!”

Bottom-of-the-mid-list miscreant. Wow.

Grady laughed uneasily. “Um, actually, Mom, this is Lila Everwood, barista, author, and soon-to-be ghostwriter.”

To her credit, she did at least look embarrassed.

I handed her the cappuccino awkwardly, and Elizabeth gestured for me to sit down on the upholstered sofa across from her. “You’re an author? Why didn’t you say something before?”

So . . . We were just going to glaze over her insult. Okay. “I thought you might want your privacy?”

She nodded. “Well, this will be a quick meeting, because I’ve decided I’m going to write my next book alone.”

I shared a look with Grady, who leaned forward. “Mom, we’ve talked about this.”

Grady clearly wasn’t in on his mother’s change of heart. And, no, it wasn’t like I was *dying* to do this. But if Elizabeth changed her mind, it was pretty clear that my relationship with Apprentice was over. And then where would that leave me?

Sometimes you have to fight for your dreams, I reminded myself.

I decided to appeal to her ego. “Elizabeth, I’m sure you have reservations about this, but it would be such an honor to work with you, to help protect and continue your peerless legacy. You are absolutely my favorite author, and to learn from you will just be the thrill of a lifetime.”

I was laying it on thick, but that was also, well, true. She did look flattered, which was good.

“Look, Lila, I’m sure you are wonderful, but I don’t *need* a ghostwriter.”

“Mom!” Grady protested. “Yes, you do!”

She shot him a look. “I don’t want my brand muddied.”

I wanted to say *Better muddied than dead*. But, instead, I went with “We will absolutely not muddy your brand. I will do everything in my power to sound exactly like you, and you will be there guiding me every step of the way. This isn’t even about us! This is for your die-hard fans. They need you. *I* need you.”

Okay. Maybe I had taken it too far. But a smile played on her lips. Wow. Okay. If I ever became this much of an egomaniac, someone had better stop me. Still, she said nothing.

“With all due respect, what’s the downside here?” How did I phrase this kindly? “You aren’t exactly, um, writing right now anyway, are you?”

Elizabeth gasped and put her hand to her chest. “*Of course* I’m still writing.”

“Are you?” Grady said under his breath.

I was getting nervous, because I didn’t seem to be swaying her. And whereas yesterday I was panicking because I didn’t want to do this, now I was panicking because I didn’t have any other choice. This was my last shot, so I took a really, really big chance. “Great!” I said sunnily. “I’d like to see what you’re working on.”

She laughed. “Excuse me. What?”

“Look, I’m here. It would be such a thrill to see how you work your magic. And then I can tell Victoria that this whole arrangement is unwarranted.”

“I will do no such thing!” Elizabeth protested. “That is absurd. Grady, tell her.”

“Actually, I agree with Lila.” He raised his eyebrows at her.

Elizabeth cut her eyes at him. “Do you want to be disinherited? Because I have no problem leaving all my money to my dogs.”

He crossed his arms. “As your agent, not as your son, I’d like to see what you’re working on.”

Her agent. Interesting.

“Fine,” she said. “*Fine*. Please, by all means, let me prove I’ve been doing the thing as natural to me as breathing. For heaven’s sake.”

As she swished down the hall, Grady grinned at me like we had a secret. I didn’t know him at all. But I already loved being on his team.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 4

Writer's Block

ELIZABETH

They wanted to see what I was *writing*? I am the queen of Regency romance with awards and bestsellers to prove it. Ninety-four framed covers line my walls floor to ceiling, and they were questioning whether I can write? My own son? We would be having *words* about this later.

I sat down at my desk, so incensed, as Grady and Lila trailed in behind me. I didn't need to be micromanaged like a child. I had earned my own money. I had made my own way in the world. Well, with my darling husband of forty years. And then, poof! He was gone, in an instant. And I was left here, drowning, with no muse, no inspiration, and . . . no writing. But just because I *hadn't* written didn't mean I *couldn't*.

I slid open my laptop, but the screen didn't brighten. That was odd. Wasn't that what always happened? When was the last time I had even been on this thing? I felt frozen. Where was the power button? I fumbled with a few buttons on the keyboard.

Grady leaned over and said, "Here, Mom, purveyor of all the words on this very machine, every day, allow me to assist you." He put his finger on a blank key, and the thing sprang to life.

Great. I was hoping it had died, and then we could stop this little charade. "I know how to turn on my own computer!" I snapped. Which was a lie. Clearly, I did not.

My heart began to pound as the thing started up. I noticed my finger was quivering ever so slightly as it ran across the trackpad, as I located Microsoft Word, as I double-clicked to open it.

Blank. All that white space. Taunting me. That blinking cursor practically laughing at how I'd lost it all. My husband. My ability to write.

My career. Everything that had made me me, that had brought me joy, was gone. Just like that.

I clicked on “File” and then “Open,” knowing that nothing new was on this laptop. So, instead, I opened an eight-year-old file that surely neither of them would remember. I scrolled down a few pages so they couldn’t see the title and said, “There! See! A manuscript.”

Grady’s and Lila’s eyes felt like they were boring a hole in the back of my head. I turned, probably to say something snarky. I wasn’t sure what yet, but I would have no problem coming up with that. Only words on a page stumped me, it seemed. But when I looked at them, their eyes weren’t on me. They were on each other. These two practical strangers seemed to be having a conversation with no words. And I had the distinct feeling it was about me.

Lila looked over my shoulder at the screen. “Elizabeth,” Lila said gently, “this is *Love Unmoored*.”

I peered at her. How did she *know* that from one measly page of text? “You should get a hobby,” I snapped. “The file I was working on must have gotten lost or accidentally deleted.”

Lila, who I barely knew, somehow found it appropriate to sit on the arm of my chair. “Let’s open a blank document and start something new,” she said gently, pitying. The girl who had one paltry not-even-close-to-bestseller was feeling sorry for me. This was definitely a low point.

“I don’t need *you* to get me started!” I retorted. “I’ve written ninety-four novels!”

Either she wasn’t listening or she simply did not care, because the girl had the gall to lean over and type *Mrs. Percy could scarcely remember a petticoat being this itchy*.

It was a silly little line. A throwaway that also made the reader want to keep reading. Why was it itchy? Was it winter? Did she have somewhere to go? An important function? The mailbox? All these questions for me to answer. It irked me that this girl probably knew that my mind would race, that I would *want* to answer all these questions. I could. I knew I could.

I put my hands back to the keyboard, but I felt suddenly exhausted and burst into tears.

Lila did the oddest thing. She *hugged* me, then knelt down beside me. “Elizabeth, look,” she said. “I’m going to level with you. I know you don’t

need me. Like you said, you have ninety-four novels to prove it. But I need you. Desperately. This is my only chance. If I ghostwrite for you, Apprentice might take a look at my next manuscript. If not, I'm out."

I sniffled, wiping away my tears. "Well, that might be for the best!" I said. "This career will wipe you out!"

She shook her head. "But it's my big dream. Not even to be a bestseller, necessarily. Just to put my words on the page and share them with the world. It's all I've ever wanted to do, since I was a little girl."

I remembered feeling like that. I did. And, well, it was clear that if Lila didn't bail me out, all that was over for me too. And, deep down, I didn't want it to be. So, I sighed deeply and said, "Fine, let's give it a go."

I was mortified that I had lost it like that. If you had asked me years earlier, I would have said I didn't believe in writer's block. But that was then. That was *before*, back when the world hadn't broken my heart. Back when I was invincible. Back when I was living a love so real I thought it could never, ever falter. Now my love had flown. And with it, obviously, had gone my talent.

CHAPTER 5

Romantic Hero

LILA

I took another sip of coffee. I had worried I would potentially fall asleep at the computer because Elizabeth had insisted on starting our first day of writing together at 7 a.m. But Elizabeth had a very specific way of making sure that could never happen.

“No, no!” she snapped. “We need a more vivid verb there. The stable boy doesn’t just *walk* to her. He *storms*.”

I looked up at her, feeling my nostrils flare. “Elizabeth, every word is not going to be perfect on my first draft. It’s sort of hard to do your best work with someone reading over your shoulder and critiquing every single word.”

She rolled her eyes and sat down in the armchair behind me. “Yes. I can see how that might be possible. But you must realize how difficult this is. I’m letting someone else do the singular thing I love most in the world. This isn’t comfortable.”

“Then get a new one,” a voice I recognized said.

“Not the chair, Grady!” Elizabeth snapped. “Having someone else write my book, for heaven’s sake.”

“Mom, it’s been, what, four hours? You have to be more open minded. Give this all a chance.”

My heart raced uneasily, because this could not fall apart. I made a mental note not to complain to Elizabeth. I needed this job. I needed her to hold up her end of the bargain. I needed another shot at my big dream.

Grady *sauntered* toward me. Elizabeth would like that better than *walked*. He smiled a smile that made my heart flutter, and handed me a manila envelope. “Your contract.”

I nodded, feeling a little uncertain.

He turned. “Mom, same for you.”

Then he turned back to me and, leaning in close, his breath on my ear sending a trail of goose bumps all along my neck and down my arm, said, "Since you don't have an agent, I was yours. I took care of you." He rested his hand on my shoulder, letting it linger.

He took care of me. He was mine.

My "thank you" came out throatily. Was it getting hot in here?

Elizabeth sighed. "I need a lunch break."

"Me too!" I said, relieved. "And more coffee!"

Elizabeth looked from Grady to me and said, "Darling, could you please take Lila to the historic site to see the Lords and Ladies display? I feel she is having a little trouble ascertaining what our characters would be wearing." She smirked at me. "And maybe get some lunch while you're at it. I need you fresh and energized for the afternoon!"

I wanted to defend myself. It wasn't that I didn't know what they would be wearing. It was that she was looming over me like a vulture, and I couldn't even *think*. But I bit my tongue.

"Don't you want to come with us?" I asked.

"No," she said pertly. "I *know* what our characters would be wearing."

Grady coughed to cover his laugh and put his hand on the small of my back, leading me toward the door.

Exiting into the bright light of the day and walking down the wooden-planked boardwalk was like stepping into a different world. I looked out over the harbor filled with beautiful sailboats and fishing boats docked for the season. It was so picturesque here. I reminded myself that all this was worth it if it meant I got to stay.

"I feel like I've just busted out of prison." I paused. "I mean, no offense. I know she's your mom . . ."

Grady laughed as our feet moved in time. "Oh, I know exactly what she's like," he said. "I'm not going to lie and say this attitude is out of character. She's always been, um, formidable." He paused. "But my dad's death changed her. He was her calming force, and I can't be what he was to her. I don't know how to fix her or soothe her like he did."

I looked over at him as we walked. "Unfortunately, I don't think anyone can fix a person's broken heart. Not even her own son. It's just a place she's going to have to get to on her own." I wondered if I was overstepping as I said, "Has it been hard on you too?"

He nodded. "My dad was my best friend, and his death was so sudden. But I think I've just been avoiding all that to try to take care of Mom." He put his hands in his pockets and looked over at me. "Sorry! Wow. Let's be less depressing."

I gasped as, as if on cue, a dolphin jumped out of the water. I grabbed Grady's arm and pointed, realizing it was a whole pod. "Talk about brightening things up!" I said.

We paused to watch them before turning up the sidewalk and into the blue historic home with gingerbread trim on a street of historic homes, where the Lords and Ladies exhibit was held. Walking inside was, truly, like walking into one of our novels. Or one of Elizabeth's, anyway, as Victoria had made it clear I no longer wrote Regencies. The original hardwood was covered in thick oriental rugs, and dark-wood furniture and velvet settees contrasted with wispy lace curtains. Mannequins were staged around the room to look natural. Ladies on a settee, men (clearly discussing the market) in the corner, the butler over by the bar cart, and so on and so forth.

"I love it here," I whispered.

"Oh, me too," Grady said sarcastically.

A tour guide was leading a group through the back rooms, so we had this parlor basically to ourselves. Grady took the opportunity to whisk a very refined top hat off one of the male mannequins and put it on his head. "Lila, darling," he said in an affected accent with maybe a touch of British, "will you join me for a snifter of brandy in the drawing room?"

I giggled and whispered, "Put that back! We're going to get in trouble!"

He did as I requested as I studied the women's hats, the fullness of their skirts, their jewelry.

"It's all rather Austen-titious, don't you think?" Grady asked, still in his affected voice.

I burst out laughing. "That is literally the worst pun I've ever heard. Are you sure you're related to one of the most famous authors in the country?"

He raised his eyebrows. "Do you really think she's one of the most famous?"

I knew my face was incredulous. "Um, yes. For sure. Are you really not aware of that?"

He walked into the dining room, and I followed. “I guess? I mean, I know I’m her agent now, but it’s hard to reconcile these two people. She has always just been Mom to me.”

“Well, I assure you, she is a legend.” I admired the ornate gold-leaf china and sterling silver on the dining table. I had been here many times, but it never got old. “A legend who is already driving me nuts,” I said.

Grady laughed. “What about your family? Do they drive you nuts too?”

I smiled. “They are the best. I grew up on this big farm a few hours from here. My parents have been married for thirty-five years. They were high school sweethearts, and the farm was their dream. And now it’s my big brother’s. He’s expanded it, and it has fully become a family business.”

Grady picked up a sterling fork, and I resisted the urge to tell him not to touch it as he said, “What about you? No farming?”

I shrugged. “Writing by the ocean. That has always been *my* dream.”

He smiled at me, his eyes locking on mine for a long moment. “You light up when you talk about writing,” he said. “I guess a lot of my clients do. But there’s something special about—”

“Excuse me!” a pert voice called. “Young man, please *do not touch* anything that is a part of the display.”

I wanted to scold the woman right back! Couldn’t she see we were *having a moment*? Then again, all the signs clearly said no touching.

“I’m so sorry,” he said. “Lila and I are here doing research for my mother, Elizabeth Lancaster.”

The woman in the bonnet gasped. “Oh my word! Why didn’t you say? How can I help?”

I smiled sweetly at her. “It’s okay,” I said. “I think we’ve gotten what we needed.”

We walked out the door, laughing like children who had been reprimanded on a field trip. The waterfront was bustling with boats and tourists, seagulls and squealing children, feeling so alive, like the embodiment of summer itself. Grady and I chatted about school and friends as we picked up sandwiches and iced coffees to go, and it felt so easy, so normal.

As we walked back into Elizabeth’s house, I said, “Thanks for taking me. I mean, I didn’t need to learn about Regency clothing, but I had fun.”

Grady held me in that gaze of his again. “You know, Lila, I did too.”

I laughed. “Well, you don’t have to sound so surprised that I’m good company.”

He smiled. “No, I just mean, let’s do it again sometime.”

“Okay! Thank you, Grady!” Elizabeth interrupted, zipping into the room. “We have hours and hours of work ahead of us.”

“Hours and hours?” I croaked.

“Welcome to the dark side,” Grady whispered, leaning close, giving me chill bumps again.

“I heard that!” Elizabeth said. “Now, get out of here. We have a book to write.”

“And contracts to sign!” Grady reminded. He put his hand on my shoulder again. “Let me know if you have any questions. I’m just a phone call away if you need anything at all.” The way he smiled made me wonder what that *anything at all* included.

As I made my way back to Elizabeth’s office, I felt like I was floating. *Let’s do it again sometime* was playing on a loop in my brain.

I got back to work. I was supposed to be writing about Mrs. Percy’s stable boy. But the only romantic hero I could think about was Grady Lancaster.

CHAPTER 6

A Damn Good Chapter

ELIZABETH

Lila struck the period with a satisfied index finger. “Now that,” she said, “was a damn good paragraph.”

I shook my head and tried to seem exasperated, but I couldn’t help but smile. “It was a damn good *chapter*,” I amended.

She gasped and turned to look at me. “Elizabeth Lancaster, did you almost say that writing together is going well?”

Writing together was a bit of a stretch, considering that Lila was doing all the writing and I was doing little more than reading over her shoulder and criticizing where I saw fit. Which was, frankly, often. Lila was bright and energetic, but she definitely lacked the polish of a more seasoned writer. Which was to be expected, I suppose. She had written one book to my ninety-four. Bless her heart, she loved developing a character and was quite adept at realistic Regency dialogue, but plot? Timeline? Which is where I came in with my trusty whiteboard, where I kept track of all our dates and movements. I couldn’t have done this without her—but I never would have admitted that out loud, of course.

I smirked. “I’m reserving judgment.”

“You-ou like me!” Lila said in a singsong voice. “It only took three weeks and thirty thousand words for you to realize it!” she teased.

I laughed and rolled my eyes.

Lila held her knees to her chest, looking so much like a child that I had to do a double take. “Liz, I think you should take this next chapter. Show me how it’s done.”

And, just like that, all my warm feelings evaporated. No one had called me Liz in three years. Not since Anthony. I glared at her. “My name is *Elizabeth*.”

Grady appeared in the doorway, which he did pretty much every day now. And, well, let's just say it didn't have much to do with me. I was a *romance* writer. I'd seen that spark between him and Lila right away—which was why I sent them on that ridiculous outing to the Lords and Ladies exhibit. Since then, there'd been a lunch here, errands there, a walk on the beach or two. But I didn't dare ask if anything was going on between them. Grady was very much like a skittish turtle about love ever since his father died. I was afraid if I so much as gently poked him, he would slide right back into his shell. So I said nothing. But I knew. Those two had a big fat crush.

"I have a meeting at Apprentice later about another author, and I wanted to give Victoria an update on your progress," he said.

"Oh, the life of an author with an agent. How sweet that must be for them." Lila grinned at him, and he laughed.

"Send me what you're working on," Grady said. "I'm happy to take a peek at your pages."

She nodded enthusiastically. "You can tell Victoria that the ghostwriting is going *great*. And my pal *Elizabeth* here is going to write the next chapter."

My breath caught in my throat. "Stop it. I am not."

Lila and Grady crossed their arms, as if in unison, which I could recognize was kind of funny, even though I was feeling panicky.

Lila got up from the computer and crouched down in front of me like she was petting a dog. She took my hands in hers. "You're brilliant. And you're ready. I just know you are."

Irritation at this *fetus* telling me what I was ready for rose in me.

"Mom," Grady said, sitting down in the chair beside me, "you've been here, day in and day out, crafting this story. Why don't you just give it a try? And if it doesn't work, no harm, no foul."

But that's what he didn't understand. I had tried so many times and failed. This project was going well. It was going *great*, actually. And, sure, Lila was writing, and I was directing, and as much as I never ever would have admitted it, we were stronger when we were together. I was terrified that if I tried and failed, even that could all fall apart for me.

Lila continued. "You are my hero. I have looked up to you since I was just a tiny little kid. And it kills me to see you give up so easily on this thing

that you are truly one of the best in the world at.”

A sound of shock I barely recognized came out of me. I couldn’t hold it in anymore. “*Give up so easily?* Do you know what it’s like to lose the man you love and then lose the thing you love to do most in the world right along with him?”

Grady and Lila shared a look I couldn’t quite read. Lila took one of my hands and laid her head on me like *she* was the puppy. She was so touchy feely. Geez. “I’m sorry, Lizzy. You’re right. I have no idea. You are so brave, and you do whatever you want. I’m just selfish and want to read your writing again.”

I wanted to protest again that my name was *Elizabeth*, but I sort of liked Lizzy. And, as much as I hated to admit it, I liked having someone who felt close enough to call me by a nickname.

Grady nodded and took my other hand. “We love you, Mom, and we want to see you step back into your talent. But if you aren’t ready, you aren’t ready.”

“I’m not ready,” I said, ripping my hands away from both of them, wondering why I was so incapable of letting myself be comforted.

Lila stood up. “Okay, Grady. Tell Victoria that we are cruising along and that I have loved stepping into Elizabeth Lancaster’s voice almost as much as I love her as a person.”

Well, now, that was sweet. This girl needed therapy. I wasn’t that nice to her, and she just kept coming back for more. I’d suggest that when we finished the book.

“I have to head out for my shift at the coffee shop,” Lila said. “But I’ll see you in the morning.”

“We’re still meeting up tomorrow, right?” Grady asked her.

Despite being ruffled a moment before, as they left, chattering about their plans, I couldn’t help but smile.

CHAPTER 7

No-Wake Zone

LILA

I was working only eight hours a week at the coffee shop, and between catering to Elizabeth's every whim, trying to get a few words of my own manuscript in each day, and you know, *sleeping*, even that was a stretch. But I couldn't let that job go. Ghostwriting was a quick blip, and I had no idea what would happen when it was over. But it was becoming clearer that if *anything* was going to happen, I needed an agent. So I was crossing my fingers Grady might want to represent me.

I had sent him my sample pages earlier, which he said he would read before we met. So, my usual I-have-a-crush-on-Grady butterflies were even more intense because now they were combined with is-he-going-to-be-my-agent butterflies.

I was tired, sure. But I was happy, too, as I walked down the boardwalk back to Elizabeth's house. Writing with Elizabeth could be exhausting, but I had also learned more from her than any MFA ever could have taught me. Not to mention that being with her meant proximity to her son.

I caught a glimpse of Grady, standing on the edge of Elizabeth's dock, looking out over the sound, and my heart clenched. He was so, so handsome. We had hung out at least five or six times in the past weeks, but he had yet to make a move, and I was unsure whether I had been permanently friend zoned. But he'd asked me to meet him here on my one fleeting day off a week from his mother, so I was hoping it meant maybe we could be something more.

I walked down the dock to see Grady dropping a paddleboard into the water.

"Hi!" he said, turning, holding his wet hands up to me.

I wanted to say *I'd take a wet hug from you any day!* But, of course, I didn't. Instead, I said, "So, uh, that took a turn yesterday, huh?"

Grady grimaced. "Yeah. I don't think Mom wants to be pushed on her writing." He shrugged. "But I don't want to talk about work! Let's paddle to the town docks to get some ice cream."

I looked down at myself. "I'd love to paddleboard, but I don't have on a bathing suit."

"Well, then, you'd better not fall in." He grinned at me.

I looked out over the marsh grass in this narrow stretch of waterway that ran in front of downtown. I had once fantasized about living in a place like this. Now I just wanted to get another book deal—and an agent. I wanted to ask Grady if he'd read my sample pages, but he had said he didn't want to talk about work, so I refrained.

Grady expertly got on his paddleboard and held mine steady with his paddle as he reached for my hand. I sat down on the edge of the dock. The tide was about midway between high and low, so the perfect height for me to place my feet on the board and, with Grady's help, stand easily.

He handed me the paddle tucked under his arm, and side by side, we sliced through the calm water.

"So, you've done this before," Grady said.

I smiled, happy that I seemed at least competent. "I have. I borrow a neighbor's board sometimes and drop it in at the public dock. I was actually going to use my first royalty check from my next book to finally get my own board, but now . . ." Well, he knew the rest.

I gasped and pointed to a wild mother horse and her foal on the island across from us, almost losing my balance.

Grady laughed. "No bathing suit. Remember?"

"That was a close one," I said.

We were quiet for a moment, held in a refreshing silence as the cicadas sang around us. I broke it, saying, "Did you always know you would be an agent? Was that always the dream?"

"Nah. When I was a little kid, I used to have this fake laptop where I'd pretend to write, just like my mom."

"Aw. That's adorable."

"But, as it turns out, I can't write."

We both laughed. "I bet that's not true!"

He shook his head. “No, it’s true. I’m, like, really bad. But that’s okay. Because I get to read for a living, which is way better, if you ask me.”

“Huh,” I said. I contemplated that. Maybe I could be an agent. A professional reader. But thinking of that electric jolt I got when my fingers touched the keyboard, I knew that would never make me fully happy.

“When you have true talent like you and my mom, it’s something pretty special. You have been given a gift.”

My pulse raced. Did that mean he had read my pages? Or my first book, even? I was too afraid to ask.

Grady jumped up onto the town dock and pulled his board out of the water. Then he took my hands, helped me up, and pulled my board up too. I looked up at the charming weathered cedar-shake building—in a line of similar buildings that looked like they’d been here forever—that held Sea Oat Sweets. This was the first time I’d seen the award-winning creamery without a line.

I walked in first, the chill inside jolting against the warm air outside. I inhaled the sweet scent. “I’ll have a waffle cone of chocolate peanut butter.”

“Good choice,” Grady said. “You can’t smell that waffle cone and then not eat it.”

I nodded. Exactly right.

I tried to pay at the old-timey brass cash register with the big black buttons, but Grady stopped me. “It’s the least I can do,” he said. “My mother has put you through it.”

“So true,” I said seriously.

The first big bite was so nostalgic. It was amazing how one bite of ice cream could put me right back into our family beach weeks and make me miss those long, lazy days with my cousins on this very beach more than I could put into words.

“Oh my gosh!” I said, looking down at the ice cream. “Writing is your mom’s ice cream!”

Grady stopped walking and scrunched his nose. “I’m sorry. What now?”

“It brings back all those memories she doesn’t want to face. Of your dad.”

He nodded. “You think?”

“Of course! You can’t write love stories—even about fake people from a different time period—and not think about your own.”

“Yeah,” he said. “I guess that makes sense.”

“I wish I could help her more.”

“You know,” he said, “I think you showing up every day, helping her get back to the page, has helped more than she could ever say.”

I smiled. Elizabeth wasn’t easy, but I could see beyond her exterior now, to that soft part she tried to hide. “I feel so honored that I get to be a part of her life and—”

Before I could finish, Grady leaned over and snagged a big chunk of my ice cream, looking so adorable I couldn’t help but laugh as I said, “Hey!”

He paused for a moment and said, “Yeah. Your chocolate peanut butter is way better than my cookie dough.”

“Really?” I asked. I leaned over and bit off a huge chunk of dough on the edge of his cone.

He shook his head. “Lila, Lila, Lila. You will come to regret that. You won’t know when. You won’t know how . . .”

We both laughed. Well, he laughed. I did something that could only be described as giggling. My face felt flushed, and my feet barely touched the ground as we continued walking.

“Do you ever think of living anywhere else?” I asked.

He nodded. “If it weren’t for my mom, I’d probably be in New York. I go back and forth once a month or so, since that’s where most of the publishing is.” He shrugged. “But now that so many people work remotely, I don’t know. I might be able to stay right here.”

“I can’t imagine a more beautiful place to live,” I said. “We came here for a family trip when I was ten, and I swore right then and there that I would live here one day. Which was kind of funny, because all I knew was farm life. But there’s something so elemental, this pull to the water.”

“Yeah, I feel that too,” Grady said. “I’m, like, off kilter when I’m away from it for too long. Which makes me wonder if I could ever actually leave.”

He looked at me for a long moment. For a beat, as we made our way back to the T-dock that held our paddleboards, I thought maybe, finally, this could be our moment. Then he said something that confused me. “The best

retribution is unexpected.” With that, Grady picked me up and tossed me gently into the water.

I absolutely could not believe it. As I came back up to the surface for air, I flailed a little and said, panting, “I can’t swim!”

“Oh my god!” Grady jumped in, too, fully clothed, in loafers that I’m sure cost more than my rent, and scooped me into his arms. “Are you okay?” he asked breathlessly, treading water. “I’m so sorry! I had no idea!”

I started laughing and splashed him. “Yeah . . . Retribution is tough!”

He laughed and splashed me back. “What you’re doing here looks quite a bit like swimming.”

“Swim team captain, all-state team, 2012 *and* 2013.”

He still hadn’t let me go. I didn’t want him to. His skin felt so good on mine.

As we both treaded water, our faces extremely close, Grady looked into my eyes. Hadn’t the last few weeks been leading up to this one inevitable moment? I had to wonder if all this publishing drama had been orchestrated so that Grady and I could meet, so that we could find each other.

My heart pounded. I could lean forward just a few inches and . . .

Before I could decide, a boat came by, going way too fast in what was supposed to be a no-wake zone, creating a huge wave that smacked us both in the face. “Hey!” Grady yelled, as if that was going to do any good.

We hoisted ourselves out of the water, laughing, but something had shifted. A door had been cracked that I wanted to walk through. But did he?

Standing on the dock, dripping wet, Grady looked at me seriously. “Hey, I have to tell you something.”

I nodded, feeling my breath quicken. This was it. This was the moment.

“I can’t be your agent.”

And, just like that, the fantasy of Grady and me washed away with the tide.

I had wanted to be a writer. I had wanted to explore these feelings with Grady. It seemed like I was coming up short everywhere these days. Maybe it was time to give up on these dreams. Which was easier said than done for a girl who was raised on wide-open spaces and fairy tales.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 8

Falling in Love Again

ELIZABETH

You know what's great about me?" I asked Lila, who, despite all my plans, I had really come to adore over the past two months of working together day in and day out. With a pace of two thousand words a day, taking Sundays off, our first draft was complete. Of course, we still had plenty of editing to do.

"Oh, gosh," she said with a touch of sarcasm. "The list is so long!"

"What I love about me," I said, "is that I have been so laid back about this entire ghostwriting process."

Lila laughed. No. Not laughed. *Guffawed*. "I'm sorry. Is that what you would call it, Lizzy?"

I loved my new nickname now that I'd had time to adjust to it. She handed me a stack of paper, and I gestured as if to say *case in point*. "Well, yes. I let you write these last three chapters *alone*."

She put her hand to her heart. "It's amazing, really," Lila said. "Me, a published author, who had written the previous thirty-six chapters with someone snapping over her shoulder *No! Not that word!* and *She should toss her hair here!* managed to produce three solo chapters!"

"Oh, the sarcasm," I said. I held the pages to my chest and grinned at her.

She smiled back. "It's good, isn't it? The book."

"Oh, it's good. Great, actually. We make an excellent team."

"I have to go to the coffee shop, but let's discuss the ending this afternoon after you've had time to digest it. I emailed a copy to you too."

After Lila left, I sat down on my couch, pulling a chunky white cotton throw over my lap, and prepared to fall into these last three chapters. I had to admit that I was hoping that, somewhere in this process, I would find my writing groove again. Unfortunately, I had not. I had been able to offer

plenty of suggestions, but I still hadn't written one stark word. It was disappointing, to say the least. But Grady was going to ask Lila if she would ghostwrite my next book, too, which seemed a better solution than giving back the advance or never putting out another novel.

I noticed that he hadn't been coming around much while she was here these past few weeks, and I wondered what that meant. Was he just busy? Or had the spark fizzled? Either way, I knew what I had seen had been real. And it made me happy that Grady's heart had thawed a little, at least temporarily.

I began reading, and right off the bat, something felt different. Something felt off. "No, no, no," I said, then sighed. "Give her an inch, and she'll take a mile."

I hurried off to the office, knowing that this would never do—and knowing how to fix it. I logged into the laptop, opened my email and the document. I pushed Lila's final three chapters down with my enter key and began to type.

Mrs. Percy had never expected to fall in love with Nathaniel. That was never the plan. He was never to be more than the stable boy who gave her her fun—and maybe a baby she could love, something that Lord Richardson would never be able to. But now, he had become more. And she felt like her heart might break if he left her here, alone in these moors to her cold castle and these frigid winter nights.

There, I thought. This is exactly where we needed to go.

I leaned back, considering what would come next, and gasped. I had done it! I had put words on paper! The dry spell was over! I wanted to call Grady, but I was too afraid I would lose it. So, I kept writing and writing, feeling that warmth spread in the center of my chest.

I had always said that writing was a little like falling in love. And here, now, at this desk, writing for the first time in more than three years, I was falling in love all over again.

CHAPTER 9

Wondrous View

LILA

As I walked down the beach, sea breeze blowing in my hair, I laughed, thinking about those horrible pages I had just given Elizabeth. The woman was a writer. Good lord, was she ever. The way she had micromanaged me . . . Well, at any rate, I hoped this was the push she needed to get back to the page. If I was wrong, if she couldn't write, I would rewrite them. But I had this sneaking suspicion that this would be the thing that finally got her back to her work. I could scarcely wait for her scolding. I was shocked she hadn't called me yet.

I was smiling to myself, watching the water lap my toes as I walked, when I looked up and spotted Grady in the distance. My stomach clenched. I had hardly seen him since he told me he couldn't be my agent. Our personal outings had abruptly stopped, and if he ever showed up at Elizabeth's, he was curt and professional. It made me sad, but I kept reminding myself that you couldn't lose something you'd never really had. Clearly, any flirtation between us had been only in my head.

Now, I wondered if he had seen me. Could I turn the other way and avoid this awkward interaction? But then he caught my eye. When he saw me, he started running, which was odd. Something must be wrong. So I started running too.

"Are you okay?" I asked when he was within earshot. He had hurt my feelings, but I still cared about his well-being.

He nodded, slightly out of breath, a ring of sweat around his forehead. His linen oxford shirt, untucked, with the sleeves rolled up; khaki shorts; and bare feet was about as casual as he got. He was so handsome I began to feel out of breath too. "Is it finished?" he asked. "The book. Is it finished?"

I didn't want to tell him about my ruse, and he seemed so panicked. I nodded. "It's finished."

“Thank god,” he said, taking my forearms in his hands, making them light up in goose bumps.

I cocked my head. “Were you worried? Did you think I couldn’t pull it off?”

He shook his head seriously. “Never. I knew from the moment I met you that you could do anything you put your mind to.”

He looked so nervous. I had been on cloud nine about my little plan with Elizabeth, but now I had the feeling that some shoe I wasn’t expecting was about to drop.

“Lila,” he said seriously.

An uncomfortable knot was forming in my stomach. *Just tell me the bad news already!* I thought.

“I couldn’t wait one more minute to tell you that the reason why I can’t be your agent . . .”

He paused, and I steeled myself. When you’re a writer, you have to develop a thick skin. But criticism from someone you admire is always hard.

He took a deep breath. “I can’t be your agent because you are all I think about,” he practically blurted out.

The knot instantly dissipated, and I laughed with relief. “I am?” I eked out.

He nodded. “You are beautiful and brilliant, and funny, and have this wondrous view of the world that I can’t get enough of. And these last few weeks, waiting to tell you that while you were working with my mother, have nearly killed me.” He paused. “Have I mentioned you’re all I think about?”

I laughed again and bit my lip. “Hey, Grady. Ever since that day at the historic site . . . you’re all I think about too.”

With that, he swept me up in his arms and kissed me in a way that felt like coming home. I realized that I knew Grady now. Over these past couple of months, I had learned that he was kind but tough when he needed to be. He was thoughtful and forthright, always. So, if he was making this move, he meant it. And I meant it too.

He smiled at me. “Was it the Austen-tatious pun?”

I nodded and stood on my tiptoes to kiss him again. When I pulled away, he scrunched his nose in that way I found so utterly charming. I

rubbed my fingers over his jawline like I had imagined doing dozens of times since we had met. And now, I could. Because he was mine.

Grady took both my hands in his. “Lila Everwood, will you go to dinner with me tonight?”

“Well, Grady, I’ll have to check my schedule.”

He laughed, and we both turned, his arm around my shoulders, mine around his waist. I briefly leaned my head toward his chest as we made our way, so slowly, down the beach toward Salty Sip. Only now, I didn’t even want caffeine. This moment with Grady was all the buzz I needed.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 10

Leave It Up to Love

ELIZABETH

My heart was racing as I got to the end.

Sometimes you have to let go, Mrs. Percy thought. Sometimes, in this life, you have to trust in God, throw away your plans, and leave it up to love. Just leave it up to love.

I stood up in my chair, triumphant, and thrust my hands in the air. I looked down at the clock. Had I really been sitting here for almost five hours with little more than a bathroom break? I needed water. Food. But I had done it! And there was nothing better in all the world than that moment as a writer where you get so lost in the story that everything else falls away. Nothing else matters but you and the words and the characters on the page. I had faced my fear. I had done it.

Thank goodness Lila had totally dropped the ball. I still wasn't sure what *that* was about. Had she needed my guidance so fully that she couldn't even write the ending by herself?

"Mom!" rang out in the entryway.

I couldn't wait to tell Grady I had finished the book. When I walked into the room, Lila was there too. Had they just jumped away from each other? Huh. So maybe they *had* been seeing each other.

"I finished the book!" I shouted, victoriously.

"You finished the book!" Lila exclaimed, throwing her arms around me.

And that was when I knew. "Those last chapters, young lady . . ." I raised my eyebrow. "You tricked me. You got me so worked up that the only choice was to rewrite them myself."

She shrugged. "I can neither confirm nor deny that that is true."

I was so grateful for her, so lit up with the fact that I had overcome this horrible thing. Maybe it was a rash decision, but I knew it was the right one. "No more ghostwriting," I said. "This book will be by Elizabeth Lancaster and Lila Everwood."

"Well, technically, alphabetically, wouldn't Lila be first?" Grady asked.

I cut my eyes at him. "My name will be first. And bigger. I'm being gracious. Let's not *lose our minds*."

Lila hugged me again. "That is so generous and so unnecessary. But I will always mark this as one of the most impactful, meaningful, amazing chapters of my life. I have learned so much from you, and I will never forget—"

"Excuse me," I interrupted, my heart racing uncomfortably. "I'm not releasing you. I think we should do it again."

Lila's eyes widened. "You do?"

I nodded. "Of course. The training wheels are off, but I'm not proficiently going it alone again yet. I'm not ready." I paused. "Plus, Mrs. Percy's stable boy is gone. What's to become of her?"

"Have you *seen* Lord Richardson's new valet?" Lila asked.

We both giggled.

"Okay," Grady said. "I might be uncomfortable with the two of you teaming up to take on the world." Then he turned to Lila and whispered, "Let's get you an agent before you negotiate this one."

"Speaking of teaming up," I said, "Lila, when you are ready, I'd very much like to give you notes—and maybe a cover blurb—on the new contemporary romance you're working on for Apprentice."

She gasped. "Really, Lizzy?"

"As long as you put *Elizabeth* Lancaster on the cover, not Lizzy." I winked at her.

Grady put his arm around Lila, and she smiled up at him. I nearly clapped. There was something brewing between them. I knew it!

I was surprised by the little jolt of joy that rushed through me. My boy had had a hard few years too. I wasn't the only one who had lost a great love. I wanted happiness for Grady; I wanted what I had had with his father for him. If this was how it found him, then it had all been worth it. All the

hard days, all the sleepless nights, wondering if I had lost not only my great love but also the single thing that brought me the most joy.

I thought about Mrs. Percy and her petticoats and the love story that Lila and I had been writing while she had been writing one of her own, and I had to wonder if someone or something had conspired to bring us all together, to put us all on this path so that we could become a new sort of family, soothe the hurts together.

I smiled, seeing the sparkle in my son's eyes, a glimmer that hadn't been there in quite a while. It made me wonder about my own future—if, somehow, someday, maybe there would be someone else out there for me. But I knew I didn't have to worry about all that now. Because what I had written? It was timeless, it was true, and I believed it with all my heart: Sometimes, you just have to leave it up to love.

OceanofPDF.com

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

True confession: I haven't written a short story since college. So when my fabulous agent, Elisabeth Weed, approached me about writing a story for the incredible Selena James, I was a little nervous—and then the ideas started pouring out of me, and I couldn't wait to dive back into short-form fiction!

Huge thanks to Elisabeth, Selena, and the talented Kristi Yanta for your guidance and suggestions, and for making this foray back into short stories so enjoyable for me. Big love, always, to my *Friends & Fiction* family: Mary Kay Andrews, Kristin Harmel, Patti Callahan Henry, Meg Walker, Ron Block, and the more than three hundred thousand of you who gather in our community each and every week to celebrate story. I always feel like I'm writing for you. Thanks to my incredible husband and son, Will and Will, and my parents, Beth and Paul Woodson, for your endless support, love, and encouragement, and for always picking up the slack when I add on another little project! Ashley Hayes and Tamara Welch, you two are always in my corner, making things come together seamlessly. I'm so grateful! The Bookstagrammers, bloggers, writers, influencers, and reporters who promote my work so tirelessly are too numerous to name here, but you know who you are. And I'm here because of you. Thank you for sharing my work as enthusiastically as if it were your own. Maybe most of all, thank you to all my readers out there who continue to share on social, write reviews, recommend my work to your book clubs, send me kind emails that keep me writing, show up to live events . . . I love you more than you will ever know. Thank you for taking your precious time to read what I have written. It means so very much!

OceanofPDF.com

ABOUT THE AUTHOR



Photo © 2025 Susan Yates

Kristy Woodson Harvey is the *New York Times*, *USA Today*, and *Publishers Weekly* bestselling author of a dozen novels, including *Beach House Rules* and the Peachtree Bluff series. *A Happier Life* is in development for film with MGM/Amazon, *The Summer of Songbirds* is in development for television with Hulu, and many of her other projects are in various stages of option or development for film and television. Her work has received numerous accolades, including *Good Morning America*'s Buzz Pick, *Southern Living*'s Most Anticipated Reads, Katie Couric's Featured Books, and JoAnna Garcia Swisher's The Happy

Place Reads. Kristy is the winner of the Lucy Bramlette Patterson Award for Excellence in Creative Writing and a finalist for the Southern Book Prize.

Kristy is a Phi Beta Kappa, summa cum laude graduate with honors of the University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill's school of journalism, and her writing has appeared in numerous publications, including *Southern Living*, *Parade*, *Traditional Home*, *USA TODAY*, and many more. She also holds a master's in English from East Carolina University, with a concentration in multicultural and transnational literature.

With fellow *New York Times* bestselling authors Mary Kay Andrews, Kristin Harmel, and Patti Callahan Henry, Kristy is the cocreator and cohost of the hit weekly web show, podcast, and Facebook group *Friends & Fiction*, which boasts more than three hundred thousand members. She is also the cofounder of the award-winning interiors site Design Chic, with her mom, Beth Woodson.

She lives with her husband; son; and dog, Salt, on the North Carolina coast—in a town quite a bit like Sea Oat Shores!—where she is (always!) working on her next novel.